

The critics, having obtained the curious phrase "go to God"—a phrase better suited to idolaters than to the God of the Decalogue or a law-giver who worshipped Him—promptly substitute "the sanctuary" for "God." But the change is fatal. It is true that we meet with a number of erections which the critics term "sanctuaries," but what were these sanctuaries? Not buildings, but altars—that is, structures, which, whatever their merits as places of worship, would not possess the one essential for this ceremony, a door or door-post. And what a curious transaction it is! A "sanctuary" we have, but no priest, no congregation, no sacrifice, no ceremony, religious or other, merely this pinning of the slave's ear to the imaginary door or door-post. Is there any parallel to this in the legislation of the Pentateuch? And could this extraordinary proceeding serve any useful purpose?

Now let us try substituting "judges" for "God." Master and slave go to the judges. Where do the judges meet? Not at the notional door of a hypothetical "sanctuary," but at the gate (Deuteronomy xxi. 19, xxv. 7; Joshua xx. 4; Ruth iv.; Zachariah viii. 16; *cf.* 2 Samuel xv. 2-6; Genesis xxiii. 18), which will certainly provide the necessary door and door-post, even though the adjoining wall may be of some material which would not lend itself to the ceremony. What happens? The slave publicly, in the presence of the very judges who would have to try the question of fact should any dispute hereafter arise, submits to having an indelible mark, which will always be evidence in case of any dispute, made on that part of his body where it will do least harm. If he should hereafter say, "True, I have this mark, but it was made without my consent," the knowledge of the judges will decide the issue. If all the judges be dead, yet, as the ceremony was public, there will be the maximum probability that some witness of